Greenfield Cooperative Bank - Employee Handbook

Joining the bank

Greenfield Cooperative Bank was founded in 1962 by a group of grape farmers in Nashik who could not get fair credit from the larger banks of the time. The cooperative began with a single branch above a fertiliser shop and a membership of two hundred and forty families. Today the bank serves farmers, small traders and salaried households across three districts, but it still describes itself first as a cooperative owned by its members rather than as a commercial lender.

This handbook explains what the bank expects from employees and what employees can expect in return. It covers working hours, leave, conduct with customers, the handling of cash and documents, and the steps for raising a grievance. Every new employee receives a printed copy during the first week and signs an acknowledgement that is kept in the personnel file. Where this handbook and a later circular from head office disagree, the later circular applies until the handbook is revised.

New employees spend their first week at the training centre in Satpur, where they shadow experienced staff, learn the core banking software and complete a short course on know-your-customer rules. Trainees are paired with a mentor from a branch other than the one they will join, so that they hear an outside view of how branches differ. Mentors meet their trainees once a fortnight for the first three months and submit a short written note after each meeting.

Attendance during training is recorded on paper and in the software, and both records must match. A trainee who misses more than two days of the induction week repeats the week with the next batch. The bank does this not as a penalty but because the induction material builds day by day, and a trainee who misses the middle days usually struggles with the branch software later.

The probation period for every new employee, whatever the grade, lasts one hundred and twenty days, and confirmation in service requires a written recommendation from the branch manager and the assigned mentor.

Working hours and leave

Branches open to the public from ten in the morning until four in the afternoon on weekdays, and from ten until one on the first and third Saturdays of each month. Staff are expected at their desks thirty minutes before opening so that cash can be counted, the vault register signed and the counters prepared. The branch manager may ask staff to stay after closing on days when the cash does not tally, and such time is recorded as extra duty.

Annual leave is earned at the rate of one and a half days for each completed month of service and can be carried forward up to a limit. Requests for leave longer than three working days must reach the branch manager at least a week in advance, except in emergencies. During the harvest months many customers visit the branches at once, so managers may restrict long leave in October and November, and they publish the restricted dates by the end of August each year.

Sick leave is separate from annual leave. An employee who is unwell must inform the branch before opening time on the first day of absence, by telephone or by a message to the manager. Absences of more than two consecutive days require a medical certificate. The bank does not ask employees to describe their illness, and managers must keep any medical documents in a sealed envelope inside the personnel file rather than in the general branch records.

Employees who wish to study for professional banking examinations may apply for study leave of up to ten days a year. The bank pays the examination fee once for each paper, provided the employee passes within two attempts. Results must be shared with the personnel department within a month of being declared, together with a copy of the mark sheet.

Each employee may also take two days of paid leave every year to volunteer with a registered charity, and the request needs only the branch manager's approval and a letter from the charity confirming the dates.

Conduct and grievances

Employees deal with members' money and private information every day, and the bank's reputation depends on how they behave both at the counter and outside work. Staff must not accept gifts from customers beyond small seasonal sweets, must not lend money to customers or borrow from them, and must declare any family relationship with a borrower whose loan they are asked to process. A declared relationship is not a problem in itself; an undeclared one is treated as serious misconduct.

Customer documents such as land records, identity papers and salary slips are scanned at the counter and the originals returned immediately. Copies must never be taken home, photographed on personal phones or sent through personal messaging accounts. When a customer asks for help filling in a form, staff may guide them but must not sign on their behalf, even when the customer cannot write and offers a thumb impression instead.

Disagreements between colleagues should first be raised informally with the branch manager. If that does not resolve the matter, the employee may submit a written grievance to the personnel department, which must acknowledge it within five working days and appoint an officer from another branch to look into it. The employee may bring a colleague of their choice to any meeting about the grievance.

Complaints of harassment follow a separate process and go directly to the internal committee, whose members are listed on the notice board of every branch. The committee meets within ten days of a complaint, and no employee may be transferred or disadvantaged for having raised a complaint in good faith, whatever its outcome.

Any employee who suspects fraud may report it anonymously through the sealed complaint box at the training centre in Satpur, which is opened only by the chief vigilance officer on the last working day of each month.